JOKE STEMS TASK

Updated March 3, 2026

This task was first presented in:

Nusbaum, E. C., Silvia, P. J., & Beaty, R. E. (2017). Ha ha? Assessing individual differences in humor production ability. *Psychology of Aesthetics, Arts, and Creativity, 11,* 231-241.

This task has become a popular way to measure creative humor production. The basic idea is to give people a "set up" consisting of a vivid, interpersonal situation and to ask them to complete it with something funny. It is important to use "be funny" instructions.

Most studies present three to six joke stems in a random order. Participants give a single, open-ended response, with no constraints on response time or length (e.g., no minimum or maximum words). Ideally, researchers would record response time and ask people to rate how funny they found their own response.

The basic structure is versatile, and researchers should feel free to add new items and vary the task's parameters.

A Qualtrics QSF file is available in the OSF folder for this task for directly importing into a survey.

Below are examples of instructions and prompts used in past work.

Burnett and Silvia (2025, PACA) Version

Burnett, M. I., & Silvia, P. J. (2025). Funny $#!%: Predicting profanity use in creative humor production. *Psychology of Aesthetics, Creativity, and the Arts*. Advance online publication. https://doi.org/10.1037/aca0000768

This project used four joke stems, shown in the table below. These joke stems are suitable for a wide range of ages (whereas some past items were tailored for college-aged populations). If you had to pick a version, this would be a good default choice.

The full version of this task, including instructions and self-ratings of humor, is available as a Qualtrics QSF file in this archive.

WRITING FUNNY JOKES

We're interested in the psychology of humor, like how people come up with funny and witty ideas.

For this task, you'll be shown the first part of a joke—an everyday, humorous situation—and your goal is to finish the joke by ***writing something funny***.

All ways of being funny are welcome. People have different senses of humor, and it's okay if your sense of humor is really "out there." ***What you write can be weird, gross, silly, dorky, bizarre, ironic, high-brow, dirty-minded, offensive, random, or whatever***, so long as you're trying to come up with something really funny.

So, on the next four pages, you will see the start of a joke. The task is to come up with a funny ending to it, like something that your friends would find funny.

There's no time or word limit. You can take as much time or as little time as you like, and what you write can be as short or long as you like. The important thing is to try to be funny.

We're interested in ***your ideas***, not something from Google, AI, or the Internet, so please come up with the ideas on your own.

Have fun with it!

[Each joke stem is presented as follows]

Here's a set-up for a joke for you to finish. Remember, what you write can be weird, gross, silly, bizarre, random, dirty-minded, or whatever, so long as you're trying to come up with something really funny:

> *Imagine that one of your friends wants your opinion on how well she sings. She sings a minute or two to demonstrate her voice, and you cringe—she might be the worst singer you've ever heard. When she asks, "So, how was it?" you decide to be honest, so you say, "To be honest, listening to that…"*

Please finish the joke by typing something funny below!

The Joke Stems Task

Prompt Name	Scenario
Gross Food	Imagine that your friend invites you over and cooks dinner—and the food is totally disgusting. Later, when describing it to another friend, you say, "Wow, that food was so bad…"
Bad Singing	Imagine that one of your friends wants your opinion on how well she sings. She sings a minute or two to demonstrate her voice, and you cringe—she might be the worst singer you've ever heard. When she asks, "So, how was it?" you decide to be honest, so you say, "To be honest, listening to that…"
Boring TV Show	Imagine that your friend is raving about a new TV drama series and says you need to watch it. Later that week you start streaming it, but you can't even make it through the first episode—it's just too confusing and tedious. Later on, when your friend asks, "What did you think of the show?" you say, "Well, …"
Dirty Car	Imagine that a new friend is picking you up so you can go shopping. You haven't seen their car before, so when it drives up you're shocked—it might be the dirtiest, messiest car you've ever seen. When your friend smiles and says, "Sorry, it's a little dirty," you laugh and say, "A little? Seriously, this car…"

Original Nusbaum et al. (2017, *PACA*) Version

For users of MediaLab, a QUE file is available in the OSF archive. This set of joke stems is tailored for college-aged participants.

JOKE COMPLETION

For this next task, you will be presented with the first part of a joke. Your job is to finish the joke by writing something funny. What you write can be weird, silly, gross, bizarre, ironic, dirty-minded, or whatever, so long as it's funny.

On the next few pages, you will see the start of a joke. The task is to come up with a funny ending to it---just press ENTER after writing your joke. There is no time limit.

Click CONTINUE to start.

++++++++++++++++++

JOKE COMPLETION

Imagine that your friend invites you over and cooks dinner---and the food is totally horrible and disgusting. Later, when describing it to someone else, you say, "Wow, that food was so bad..."

Please complete the phrase "Wow, that food was so bad..." with something funny below.

++++++++++++++++++

JOKE COMPLETION

Imagine that one of your classes this semester is incredibly boring, and you're trying to convey just how incomprensibly boring this class is to one of your friends. So you say, "Seriously, that class is so boring, ..."

Please complete the phrase "Seriously, that class is so boring, ..." with something funny below.

++++++++++++++++++

JOKE COMPLETION

Imagine that one of your friends wants your opinion on how well she sings. She sings a minute or two to demonstrate her voice, and you cringe---she might be the worst singer you've ever heard. When she asks, "So, how was it?" you decide to be honest, so you say, "To be honest, listening to that..."

Please complete the phrase "To be honest, listening to that was like..." with something funny below.

Burnett and Silvia (2025, JRP) "Mean" Version

Burnett, M. I., & Silvia, P. J. (2025). Vulgarity and hilarity: the dark tetrad and HEXACO as predictors of creating aggressive, obscene, and otherwise offensive humor. *Journal of Research in Personality*, 104667.

For a project about vulgar, rude, and offensive humor, the prompts were reworked to encourage and afford a wider range of responses. Some joke stems were developed that had three characters: the participant, a friend, and a stranger who did something odd or eccentric. The prompt allows the participant to say something to their friend out of earshot of the stranger. This kind of scenario should loosen social restraints around disparaging and offensive humor.

The instructions are basically the same; the prompts are shown below.

The Joke Stems Task Used in "Vulgarity and Hilarity"

Prompt Name	Scenario
1. Gross Food	Imagine you and a friend are ordering something to eat at a new food truck. After the truck's cook hands over your food, you and your friend walk off to a nearby bench to eat. You take a big bite—and the food is totally disgusting. You turn to your friend, and say, "…."
2. Dirty Car	Imagine that you and your friend are waiting for a rideshare car. When the car pulls up, you're shocked—it's dirty, trashy, and grimy. After the ride, when you're getting out, the driver smiles and says, "Sorry, it's a little bit dirty today," and then drives off. You look at your friend and say, "…."
3. Bad Singing	Imagine you are sitting outdoors at a coffee shop with a friend, and nearby a street performer with a guitar and microphone is singing to people passing by. You cringe as they enthusiastically belt out the big final note of a song—they're a terrible singer. When the song is over, you turn to your friend and say, "…."

4. Beach Weirdo	Imagine you and a friend are walking along the beach on a sunny day, and you pass by someone under a huge beach umbrella who is busy clipping towels to it to block the sun. When you look closer, you see that they're coated in thick, caked-on sunscreen from head to toe, and empty sunscreen bottles are strewn nearby. After you walk by, you look at your friend and say, "...."
5. Strange Outfit	Imagine you and a friend are sitting on a park bench, watching people pass by. Suddenly, someone walks by wearing an outrageous and outlandish outfit, with clashing colors and bizarre accessories. After they pass, you turn to your friend and say, "...."
6. Eccentric Coffee	Imagine you and a friend are in line at a local coffee shop, waiting to order. Just then, a customer storms up to the counter, holding their coffee, and loudly complains, "Excuse me! I ordered a triple-shot vanilla matcha chai caramel latte with almond milk, oat foam, and two sprinkles of cinnamon—this is all wrong!" You turn to your friend and quietly say, "...."